
Introduction

In a transdisciplinary collaboration, there are many differences between team members. These differences are often perceived as challenging — but they can also be leveraged. By **recognizing, valuing, and actively using diversity**, you can improve both collaboration and outcomes.

According to Smeenk (2023), three key dimensions in which team members differ in transdisciplinary collaboration are:

1. **Interest**
2. **Power**
3. **Knowledge**

On the practice page, you'll already find some real-world experiences and tools that can help.

More explanation about these three dimensions — interest, power, and knowledge — will be added soon to the **Theory** page.

Note: The in-depth theory page on this topic is not yet available. Authors of the TRAIL tool are currently working on a review study of transdisciplinary collaborations. Knowledge from this study will be added here soon. You can already check out an introduction to this new research and the researchers here: [Scoping review transdisciplinaire samenwerkingen | Avans Hogeschool](#)

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Theory

Transdisciplinary work is a process, and so is gathering and collecting knowledge and tools about it. More information will follow soon. Sign up for the TRAIL newsletter to stay informed about content updates!

Practice

It's important to **identify and surface diversity** — you can ask questions about differences. This approach is based on the **Co-Design Canvas** by Wina Smeenk (2023).

Diversity in Interest

As a team member, you participate in a transdisciplinary project for different reasons — personal, financial, or work-related. Ask yourself: *Who has which interests, and why?*

Be honest.
These interests are not always visible. If they remain unspoken, the process can become complex and frustrating. So speak up, help resolve conflicts constructively, and contribute to better and more creative solutions.

Diversity in Power

Transdisciplinary collaboration almost always involves **unequal**

power dynamics. A person's role, network, knowledge, or personality can influence their power. If these dynamics are ignored or left unspoken, they can lead to frustration.

But power can also be used constructively (Het Groene Brein, 2023). Dreaming together about the future and your shared goal is a first step. Talk about how achieving the shared goal will shift the positions of all parties — you're creating a new playing field. This means powerful players may need to give up or change things. The shared goal takes precedence over individual interests.

Diversity in Knowledge

The **variety of knowledge types** among team members is the foundation of your project. This includes a mix of scientific and practical insights that contribute to:

- **System knowledge** (understanding current reality)
- **Goal knowledge** (visualizing the desired outcome)
- **Transformational knowledge** (moving from system knowledge to goal knowledge)

(Het Groene Brein, 2023)

Participants bring different types of knowledge from their experiences or lifestyles. Make visible what each person's knowledge, expertise, and experience are — and what kind of knowledge they can and want to contribute.